

Word family: **chain / chains / chained / chaining**

Base word: chain

Plural: chains

Past tense: chained

Past participle: chained

** -ing form:** chaining

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Your sentence:

> “He then showed me how to check the **chain**, clean the gears, and replace a worn-out part.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **chain** means the **metal looped mechanism on a bicycle that transfers movement from the pedals to the wheel**.

繁體中文：***由一連串金屬鏈節組成、用來把踩踏力量傳到車輪的單車鏈條**

中文翻譯：

> “...how to check the **chain**...”

「.....如何檢查單車的**鏈條**.....」

Here:

bicycle chain = 單車上把腳踏的動力傳到車輪的金屬鏈條

1. **chain = linked metal loops (實物) — 鏈 ; 鏈條**

This is the central literal meaning and the one used in your passage.

Meaning: A series of connected metal rings or links used for fastening, pulling, transmitting movement, etc.

Practice 1 — Original

> “He showed me how to check the **chain**.”

「他教我如何檢查單車的**鏈條**。」

Practice 2

> “The gate was secured with a heavy **chain**.”

「大門用一條粗重的**鐵鏈**鎖住。」

Practice 3

> “The bicycle **chain** needs oil.”

「單車**鏈條**需要上油。」

chain = 由一連串相連的金屬環 / 鏈節組成的長條物

Common:

* bicycle chain

* metal chain

* chain lock

* chain link

2. **chain** = series of connected things/events (連串) — 一連串 ; 連鎖

Chain can mean a sequence in which things are linked together.

Practice 4

> “One mistake led to a **chain** of problems.”

「一個錯誤引發了一**連串**問題。」

Practice 5

> “The decision caused a **chain reaction**.”

「這項決定引發了**連鎖反應**。」

chain = 多個事件、因素或事物彼此相連，形成有次序的連續關係

This is a major figurative extension of the physical-link idea.

3. **chain** = group of businesses under one ownership/brand (商業) — 連鎖店 ; 連鎖企業

A **chain** can mean a group of shops, restaurants, hotels, etc. operated under the same name or ownership.

Practice 6

> “She works for a large hotel **chain**.”

「她在一家大型酒店**連鎖集團**工作。」

Practice 7

> “The restaurant is part of an international **chain**.”

「這間餐廳屬於一個國際**連鎖品牌**。」

chain = 多間以同一品牌、所有權或管理系統經營的店舖 / 企業

This is distinct enough for learners to keep separately.

4. **chain** = connected sequence in geography/nature (地理) — 山脈；島鏈；連串

Chain can describe a line or series of geographical features.

Practice 8

> “A long mountain **chain** stretches across the region.”

「一條長長的**山脈**橫跨這個地區。」

Practice 9

> “The islands form a **chain** across the sea.”

「這些島嶼在海上形成一條**島鏈**。」

chain = 在空間上連續排列的一系列地形或地理事物

For strict counting, I would merge this with Meaning 2 under the broader **connected series** concept.

5. **chain** = sequence of responsibility/supply/etc. (系統關係) — 鏈；體系

In established compounds, **chain** refers to linked stages or levels in a system.

Examples:

- * supply chain
- * food chain
- * chain of command

Practice 10

> “The company is trying to improve its supply **chain**.”

「公司正嘗試改善其供應**鏈**。」

Practice 11

> “Energy moves through the food **chain**.”

「能量沿着食物**鏈**傳遞。」

chain = 多個步驟、層級或參與者依次相連形成的系統

This is another strong domain extension of the **connected sequence** sense, so I would merge it semantically with Meaning 2.

6. **chain** = restraint / symbol of captivity (束縛) — 鎖鏈 ; 束縛

Chains, especially in the plural, can refer to restraints used to prevent someone from moving freely.

Practice 12

> “The prisoner was kept in **chains**.”

「那名囚犯被**鎖鏈束縛着**。」

Practice 13

> “The image of broken **chains** often symbolizes freedom.”

「斷裂的**鎖鏈**形象常象徵自由。」

chains = 用來限制活動的鎖鏈 ; 亦可比喻束縛

This is physically related to Meaning 1 but functionally distinct enough to show.

7. **chain** = fasten/restrain with a chain (動詞) — 用鏈鎖住；拴住

As a verb, **chain** means to fasten or secure someone or something with a chain.

Practice 14

> “He **chained** the bicycle to the fence.”

「他用鏈鎖把單車鎖在圍欄上。」

Practice 15

> “The gate was **chained** shut.”

「大門被用鐵鏈鎖住。」

chain something = 用鏈條把某人 / 某物固定、鎖住或限制其移動

This is the main verb meaning.

8. **chain** = link things together figuratively (動詞) — 串連；連接

Less commonly, **chain** can mean linking things together in sequence.

Practice 16

> “The system **chains** several processes together.”

「這個系統把幾個程序串連起來。」

Practice 17

> “The tasks are **chained** in a fixed order.”

「這些任務按固定次序串連在一起。」

chain things = 把多個元素按順序連接成一個連續系統

This is a direct figurative extension of the physical-link idea.

For core counting, I would merge it under the broader verb **link/fasten** concept.

Important distinction: **chain vs link**

chain

can mean the whole connected series.

link

often means one individual connection or one element in that chain.

> a chain of events

> one link in the chain

So:

chain = 整條鏈 / 整個連鎖

link = 其中一環 / 連結點

Important distinction: **chain vs rope**

chain

is normally made of connected metal links.

rope

is made from twisted or braided fibres.

Both can tie or secure things, but their structure is different.

Important distinction: **chain vs network**

chain

often suggests a sequence:

$A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow D$

network

suggests many interconnected points, not necessarily in one line.

So:

> supply chain

focuses on linked stages.

> communication network

focuses on many interconnected nodes.

Important distinction: **chain vs series**

series

simply means a number of things occurring one after another.

chain

adds the idea that the elements are **linked or causally connected**.

> a series of events

may just happen in sequence.

> a chain of events

strongly suggests one event leads to another.

Useful compound: **chain reaction — 連鎖反應**

Practice 18

> “The first error caused a **chain reaction**.”

「第一個錯誤引發了**連鎖反應**。」

****chain reaction = 一個事件引發下一個，再引發更多事件的連續反應****

This belongs to the connected-series sense.

Useful compound: **chain of command** — 指揮系統 / 層級

Practice 19

> “The request must go through the proper **chain of command**.”

「這項要求必須按正式的**指揮層級 / 管理層級**處理。」

chain of command = 權力或指揮由上而下依次排列的層級系統

This is a fixed institutional compound rather than a new core sense.

Related-family note

The practical modern family is small:

* **chain**

* **chains**

* **chained**

* **chaining**

Most of the learning value comes from compounds and metaphorical extensions:

* bicycle chain

* chain reaction

* supply chain

* food chain

* chain of command

* hotel chain

* mountain chain

The Golden Manual says compounds and domain uses should be swept broadly, but grouped under the same underlying meaning when the same semantic image still works.

Master comparison

| Form / sense

| MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning |

| ----- | ----- |

| **chain** — metal links

| 由一連串相連金屬環 / 鏈節組成的鏈條

|

chain — connected series	多個事件、事物、階段或單位彼此相連形成的一連串
關係	
chain — business group	多間以同一品牌、所有權或管理系統經營的連鎖企業 /
店舖	
chains — restraint	用來限制活動的鎖鏈；亦可比喻束縛
chain — verb	用鏈條把某人 / 某物固定、鎖住或串連起來
chain reaction / supply chain / food chain	以「一環接一環」概念形成的連鎖 / 鏈式系統

For your original sentence

> "...how to check the **chain**, clean the gears..."

The exact meaning is:

chain = 單車上由金屬鏈節組成、把腳踏力量傳到車輪的鏈條

So:

> **check the chain**

= **檢查單車鏈條**

For your database, I would count **4 genuinely useful core meanings** for **chain**:

1. **a physical chain made of connected links**
2. **a connected sequence or system**
3. **a group of businesses under one brand/ownership**
4. **verb — fasten or link something with a chain**

I would keep **supply chain, food chain, chain reaction, chain of command, mountain chain** under #2 as domain/compound extensions, and treat restraint **chains** as a prominent functional branch of #1 rather than inflate the core count further.